

Breast & Axilla Physical Exam Checklist

Diagnostic Medicine III 2026

FEMALE BREAST EXAMINATION		
Wash hands and don appropriate PPE		
Chaperone	Chaperone should be present for all male and female GU exams: "I will have the nurse/HCP present to assist/ chaperone." ☑	
Consent	"Will it be OK if I examine your breasts and underarms?" "Do you have any questions before we begin?"	
Patient Position & Draping	Patient is sitting on exam table with arms at side. Patient should have a gown open to the front or be disrobed from the waist up.	
Seated Position		
Inspection (verbalize) SSCC VLDR SSSC Nipple inversion, Nipple retraction supernum nipple	Compare both breast for:	
	Size	
	Symmetry	you said shape
	Contour	
	Retractions or dipping	
	Skin color or texture	
	Venous patterns	
	Lesions	
	Compare both areolae and nipples for:	
	Shape	
	Symmetry	
	Color	
	Smoothness	
	Nipple inversion, retraction	
	Supernumerary nipples	
	Repeat inspection with patient in the following positions: verbalize	
	Arms extended over the head or flexed behind the neck	
	Hands pressed on the hips with shoulders rolled forward	
Seated and Leaning forward		
Palpation	Perform a <u>chest wall sweep bilaterally</u> (Placing palm of hand at the patient's sternum and clavicle and sweep downward from the clavicle to the nipple. Repeat until the entire side of the chest wall has been palpated. Repeat on the opposite side)	
	Perform bimanual digital palpation bilaterally (Placing palmar surface facing up under the breast and using the other hand, gently compress the breast tissue against the flat surface of the palm moving across the breast)	
	Central axillary lymph nodes	
	*If central nodes feel large, hard, or tender, palpate the other axillary lymph nodes (pectoral, lateral, suprascapular, infra/supraclavicular) (verbalize)	
Supine Position		
Inspection (verbalize)	Compare both breast for:	
	Size	
	Symmetry	you said shape
	Contour	
	Retractions or dipping	
	Skin color or texture	
	Venous patterns	
	Lesions	
	Compare both areolae and nipples for:	
	SSCC VLDR	

SSSC • Nipple inversion • Nipple retraction • Supernumerary nipples	Shape	
	Symmetry	
	Color	
	Smoothness	
	Nipple inversion, retraction	
	Supernumerary nipples	
Palpation of Breast	Palpate the right breast using <u>light</u> , <u>medium</u> , <u>deep</u> pressure. (May use the <u>verticle strip</u> , circular, or wedge method for palpation)	
	Palpate the left breast using <u>light</u> , <u>medium</u> , <u>deep</u> pressure. (May use the verticle strip, circular, or wedge method for palpation)	
	<i>*Patients with larger breasts may need to rotate positions for optimal examination. Supine position for medial breast palpation. Modified left lateral position (knees flexed to side with patient on opposite hip) for lateral breast palpation. (verbalize)</i>	
	Depress the nipple into the well behind the areola bilaterally <u>use both hands on either side</u>	

MALE BREAST EXAMINATION		
Patient Position & Draping	The patient is in sitting or supine position, disrobed from the waist up.	
Chaperone	Chaperone should be present for all male and female GU exams: "I will have the nurse/HCP present to assist/ chaperone." ☐	
Consent	"Will it be OK if I examine your breasts and underarms?" "Do you have any questions before we begin?"	
Inspection (verbalize) SSSS SSSC	Compare both breast for:	
	Size	
	Symmetry	
	Surface characteristics	
	Compare both areolae and nipples for:	
	Shape	
	Symmetry	
	Color	
	Smoothness	
	Nipple inversion, retraction	
Palpation	Breast bilaterally for masses	
	Areolae bilaterally for texture	
	Central axillary lymph nodes	
	<i>If central nodes feel large, hard, or tender, palpate the other axillary lymph nodes (<u>pectoral</u>, <u>lateral</u>, <u>suprascapular</u>, <u>infra/supraclavicular</u>). (verbalize)</i>	